

Nutrition Credentials and Qualifications

Nutrition Credential	Description
Registered Dietitians/ Registered Dietitian Nutritionist (RD/RDN)	• Nationally recognized and credentialed in nutrition by the Commission on Dietetic Registration (CDR). Scope of practice ranges from clinical nutrition to community, food service, and nutrition education. • Although nationally recognized, some states might still require RDs to obtain state licensure prior to practicing independently or in a clinical or medical setting.
Certification as a Specialist in Sports Dietetics (CSSD)	• A certification for registered dietitians who have extensive practice experience (2,000+ hours) in the field of sports nutrition.
Certified Dietitian/Nutritionist (CDN) or Licensed Dietitian/Nutritionist or (LD/LDN)	• State Certified or Licensed Nutritionist. Licensed to practice nutrition in the certifying/licensing state. • This licensure might be legally required in some states, for both RDs and non-RDs, to provide any nutrition counseling.
Certified Nutrition Specialist (CNS)	• Certified by the Board for Certification of Nutrition Specialists. • This certification qualifies individuals for licensure as a CDN or LD/LDN in some states.
Certified Nutrition Specialist (CNS)	• A generic term indicating certification in nutrition by an organization. It is important to determine which organization is providing the certification, if they are an accredited organization, and if the accreditation qualifies the holder for the legal practice of nutrition. • Accredited organizations are officially recognized and authorized to provide a qualification, as they are reviewed by other governing bodies and found to meet or exceed the minimum standards for education.